Threshold Group Deals — Spec

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Overview

A threshold group deal unlocks a lower price only if enough households commit by a deadline. Example: 2.5 lb bags of apples at $1.80/lb if 20 households join by Thursday.

- **For farmers:** guaranteed volume before harvest, less waste, and a demand signal they can plan around.
- **For shoppers:** a visible discount, a reason to rally neighbors, and a clear stake in the outcome.
- **For HarvestHub:** a repeatable engagement loop and a strong subscriber benefit (24-hour early access).

HarvestHub is merchant of record, so all charging, refunds, tax and payouts run through the platform.

Deal setup

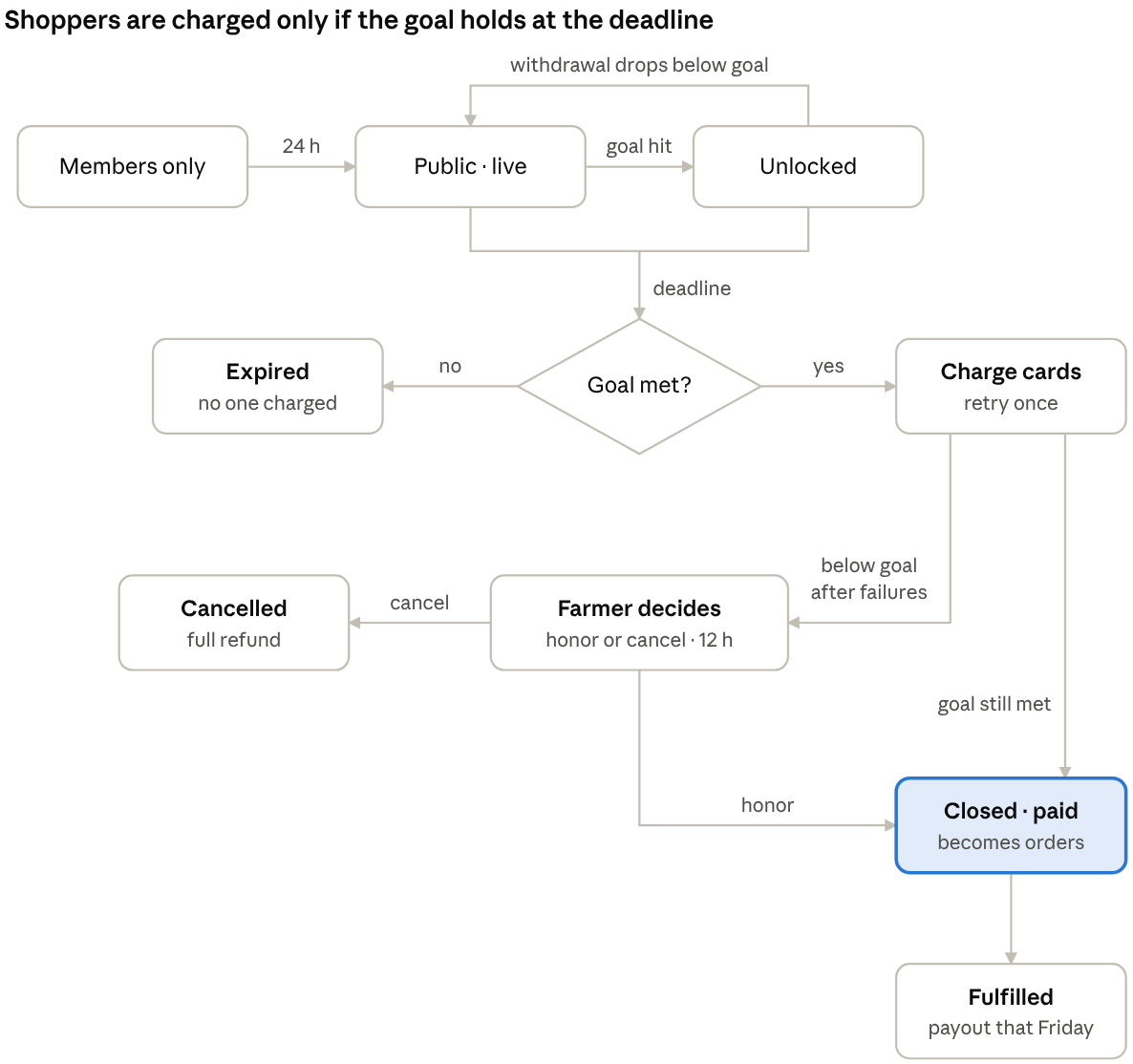
The farmer sets threshold (households) and supply cap (lbs) separately, so a deal can keep selling after it unlocks.

Field	Example	Rule
Product	Honeycrisp apples	Produce only at launch (no eggs, meat or dairy)
Share size	2.5 lb bag	Fixed per deal; one share per household
Deal price	$1.80/lb ($4.50/share)	Must be below regular price
Regular price	$2.40/lb	Shown struck through for savings
Threshold	20 households	Drives the progress bar
Supply cap	75 lbs (30 shares)	≥ threshold × share size; default 1.5×
Member window	24 hours	Subscribers only, starts at publish
Public open	Publish + 24 h	Automatic

Field	Example	Rule
Deadline	Thursday 11:59 PM ET	⩾ 48 h after public open; farmer's time zone
Fulfillment date	Saturday	⩾ 48 h after deadline

If the farmer sets the cap equal to the threshold, warn them: the deal will fill exactly at goal and close to everyone else.

State machine



group deal lifecycle · 9 states, 1 decision

"Unlocked" is provisional: withdrawals can drop a deal back to Live until the deadline, when the goal check decides the outcome.

Commit rules

One commit per household per deal, counted by delivery address, paid by a saved card charged only at close.

- **Household dedupe:** a household = a verified delivery address. A second account at the same address can't commit to the same deal.
- **Neighborhood Pods:** each subscribing household in a Pod counts toward the goal on its own; the Pod shares one drop point. A household already committed individually isn't counted again through its Pod. Pod members see their combined contribution on the bar ("Your Pod: 5 households").
- **Member early access:** for the first 24 hours only subscribers can commit. Non-members see the live bar with a "Members joining now" label and a subscribe prompt.
- **Filled by members:** if subscribers reach the supply cap inside the window, the deal never opens publicly and non-members see "Filled by members."
- **Payment method:** card saved at commit (no authorization hold, since holds typically expire in about 7 days). Shopper sees "You won't be charged unless the deal unlocks."
- **Withdrawal:** free until the deadline. The bar goes down when someone leaves; we show that honestly.
- **After goal, before cap:** commits keep counting until the cap or the deadline, whichever comes first.
- **Concurrency:** each commit runs in a database transaction that checks the cap, with an idempotency key, so two people can't take the last share.
- **Waitlist:** once the cap is hit, shoppers can join a waitlist; a withdrawal offers the share to the next household for 2 hours.

Close logic

At the deadline a close job (a full cap doesn't close early; the waitlist covers withdrawals) decides the deal's outcome; no one is charged unless it succeeds.

1. Freeze commits. Count committed households.
2. **If count ≥ threshold:** charge every saved card at the deal price.
    - Failed charge → one automatic retry after 2 hours, with a "fix your card" notice.

    - Still failing → that household is dropped and its share released.
3. **If failures push the count below threshold:** the farmer has 12 hours to choose.
    - **Honor:** keep the deal at $1.80/lb for everyone who paid.
    - **Cancel:** refund everyone in full. No trust-score penalty, since the failure wasn't the farmer's.
    - No answer in 12 hours → honor by default (shoppers already paid and expect produce).
4. **If count < threshold at deadline:** deal expires, no charges.
    - Optional: if the farmer opted in at setup, committed subscribers get an offer to buy at regular price, valid 24 hours (members only; non-subscribers don't get this offer). Each shopper chooses; no one is converted automatically.
5. Post the result to everyone: unlocked, expired, or cancelled.

Money flow

Deal revenue follows the standard payout rules: 10% commission off the line subtotal, paid in the pay period of the fulfillment date.

Step	When	Example (20 shares × $4.50)
Shopper charged	At close	$90.00 subtotal + tax + delivery
Commission	Off line subtotal only	$9.00 (10%)
Farmer earnings	Accrue on fulfillment date	$81.00
Payout	Friday of that Sat–Fri pay period	Included in weekly payout

- **Harvest shortfall:** if the farmer delivers less than committed, missing shares are refunded automatically and pro-rata. Commission is taken only on what was delivered.
- **Cancelled after charge:** full refund to shoppers; nothing accrues to the farmer.
- **Tax:** computed at charge time by delivery address, as with regular orders.

Farmer edit rules and trust

Once the first shopper commits, farmers can only change terms in shoppers' favor. There is no limit on concurrent live deals.

Change	Allowed after first commit?
Lower the deal price	Yes; all committers get it
Lower the threshold	Yes
Raise the supply cap	Yes
Extend the deadline	Once, up to 72 hours; committers notified and may withdraw
Raise price, shrink share, raise threshold	No
Move deadline earlier, lower cap below commits	No
Cancel the deal	Yes, with a trust-score penalty

Trust score signals (shown in the farmer portal's trust section):

- Deals cancelled by the farmer
- Share of deals that expire unmet (a high rate suggests thresholds set too high)
- Harvest shortfalls after a successful close

We use these to coach, not punish: e.g. suggest a lower threshold when a farmer's last three deals expired.

Progress bar

The bar fills by households toward the threshold, then switches to showing shares left against the cap. See the linked prototype for each state.

State	Bar	Headline copy	Button
Members only	Vine fill, lock icon	"Members joining now · 6 of 20"	Join (members) / Subscribe to join early
Live	Vine fill	"14 of 20 households · 6 to go"	Commit to this deal
Almost there (≥ 80%)	Sweetcorn pulse	"Just 3 more to unlock $1.80/lb"	Commit · Share with neighbors

State	Bar	Headline copy	Button
Unlocked	Full, Sweetcorn	"Unlocked! $1.80/lb · 8 shares left"	Grab a share
Full	Full, muted	"All 30 shares claimed"	Join waitlist
Committed (you)	Your household marked on the bar	"You're in · charged only if it unlocks"	Withdraw
Expired	Beet outline	"Didn't reach 20 · no one was charged"	See farmer's other deals

- Countdown shows days until the last 24 hours, then hours and minutes.
- "Why this price" link opens the regular vs. deal price breakdown (transparency principle).
- Milestone ticks at 50% and 100%; past the threshold, a second segment shows overflow toward the cap.

Notifications

Shoppers hear about progress only on deals they've joined or saved; farmers hear every milestone.

Trigger	Shopper	Farmer
Deal published	Subscribers following the farm	Confirmation
Public open	Followers who aren't members	—
50% of threshold	Committed households	Yes
80% of threshold	"3 more to go" + share link	Yes
Unlocked	Committed + saved	Yes
24 h left, below threshold	Committed: "invite a neighbor"	Warning + option to lower threshold
Charge failed	Fix-card prompt	—

Trigger	Shopper	Farmer
Honor-or-cancel needed	—	Urgent, 12 h timer
Final result	Everyone committed	Summary + earnings
Waitlist share opens	Next waitlisted household	—

At most one progress push per shopper per deal per day, to avoid fatigue.

Data model sketch

Three new tables; everything else reuses existing orders and payouts.

Table	Key fields
`group_deal`	id, farmer_id, listing_id, share_lbs, deal_price_per_lb, regular_price_per_lb, threshold_households, cap_shares, member_open_at, public_open_at, deadline_at, fulfill_on, state, extended_once, regular_price_fallback
`group_commit`	id, deal_id, household_id (address), user_id, pod_id (nullable), payment_method_id, status (active, withdrawn, charged, failed, refunded), idempotency_key, created_at
`group_waitlist`	id, deal_id, household_id, position, offered_at, offer_expires_at

On a successful close, each charged commit becomes a normal order line, so commission, tax, payout and 1099-K reporting need no special handling.

Decisions

- **Product scope:** produce only at launch. Eggs, meat and dairy come later, once conditional compliance checks are wired into deal setup.
- **Charge failures below goal:** honor by default if the farmer doesn't respond within 12 hours.

- **Regular-price fallback on expiry:** subscribers only.
- **Pod visibility:** Pods see their combined contribution on the bar.